AITrace user manual

AITrace helps you find and understand AI code changes. Read what changed and why, then decide what to keep. This guide uses the Pending task-list sample shown in the screenshots.

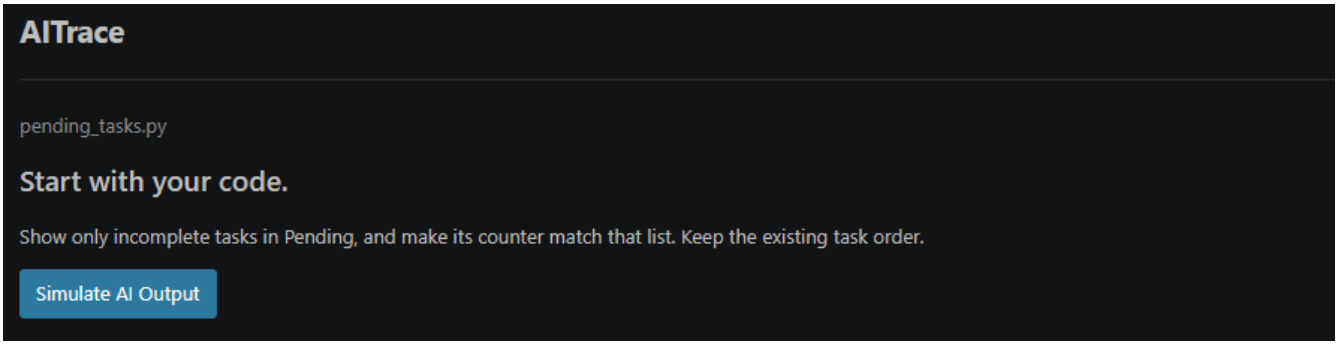
Install and open a sample

Use desktop VS Code. Download the AITrace .vsix file. In Extensions, open the **...** menu, choose **Install from VSIX...**, and select the file. Reload VS Code if prompted.

Open the Command Palette with **Ctrl+Shift+P** (Windows/Linux) or **Cmd+Shift+P** (macOS). Run **AITrace: Start Demo** and choose **Review - Pending task list**. A fresh Python sample opens beside the AITrace panel.

Simulate AI output

Read the task, then click **Simulate AI Output**. It loads three prepared suggestions, ready for review. You can also use the AITrace entry above the code.

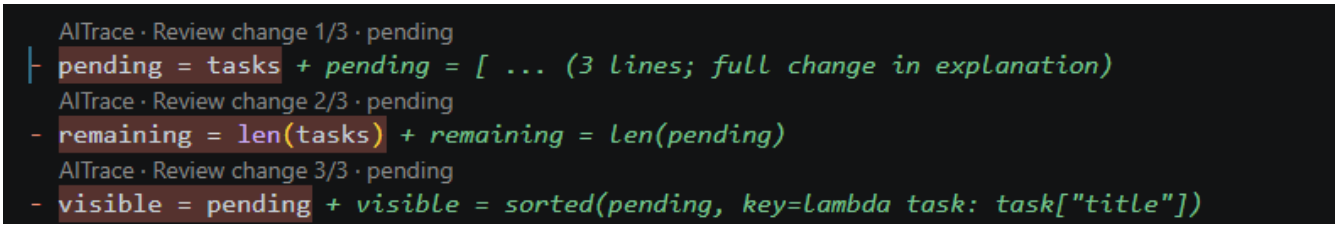


The starting panel shows the sample task and the Simulate AI Output button.

This demo stands in for output from another AI assistant. It works offline and needs no AI account, API key, or Python installation. It does not generate new answers or run the sample code. You can try the smaller **Practice - Course result** case first if you prefer.

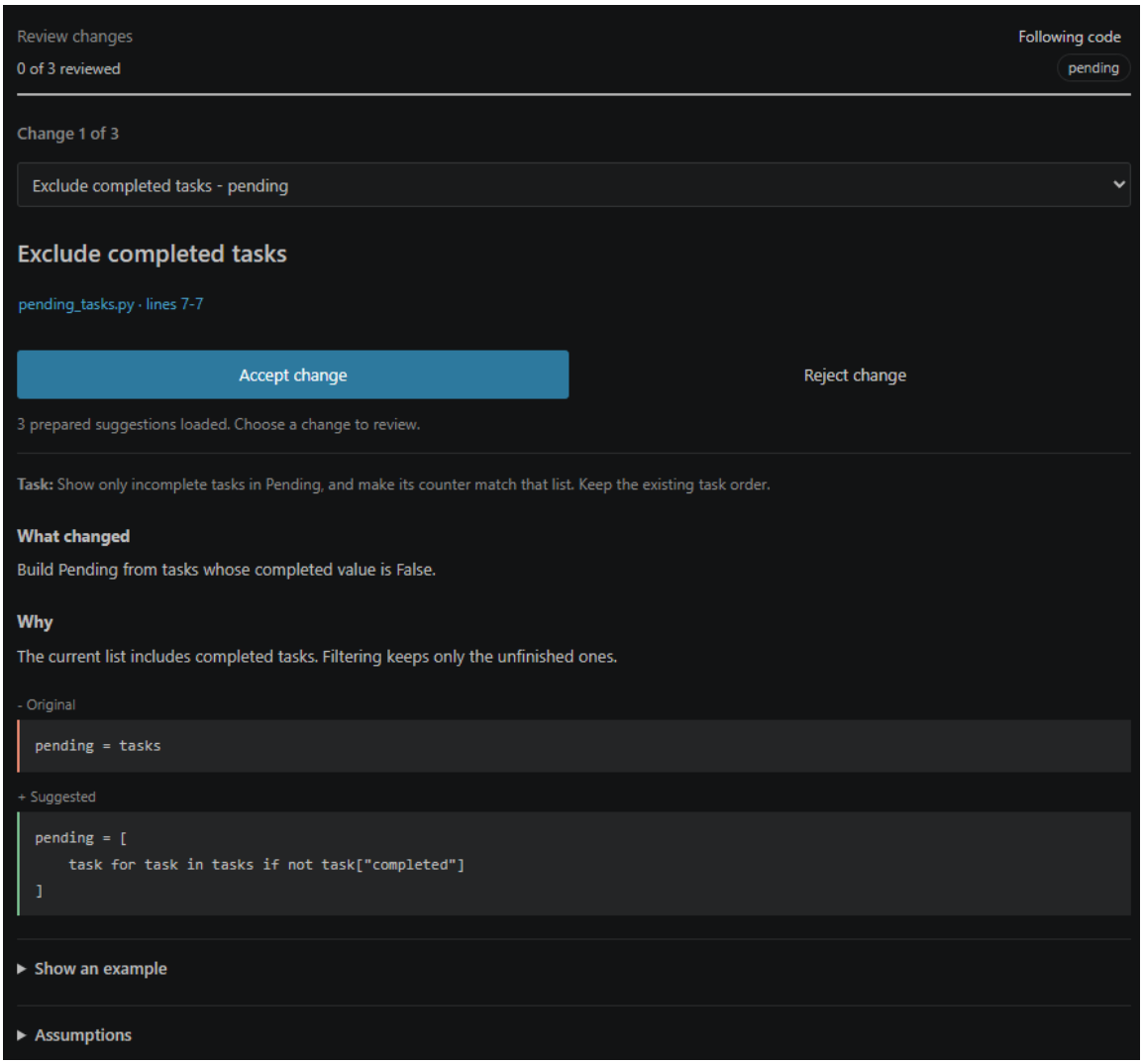
Find a change and read its explanation

Click an **AITrace - Review change** entry above a changed block. The minus marker shows original code; the green plus preview shows the proposal. Longer previews are shortened in the editor, with the full block in the panel.



Each changed block has its own review entry and a short code preview.

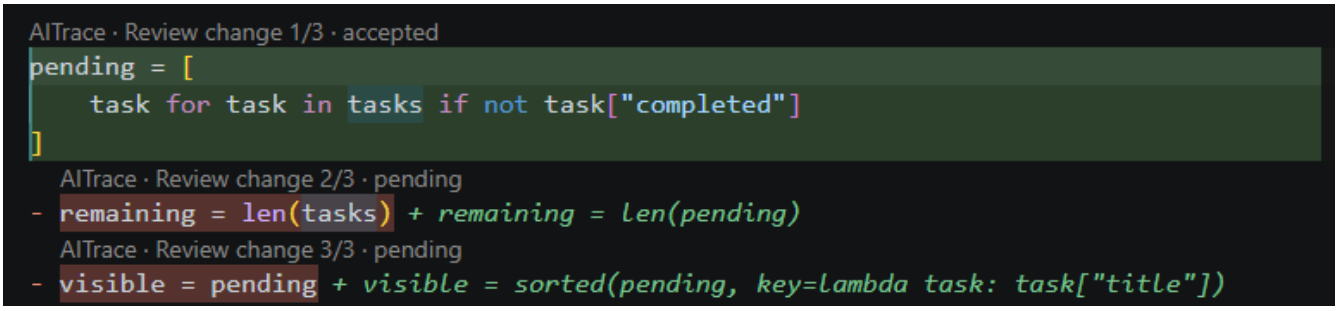
In the panel, read **What changed** and **Why**, then compare **Original** and **Suggested**. Expand **Show an example** or **Assumptions** if you want more detail. These are prepared explanations, not a live chat.



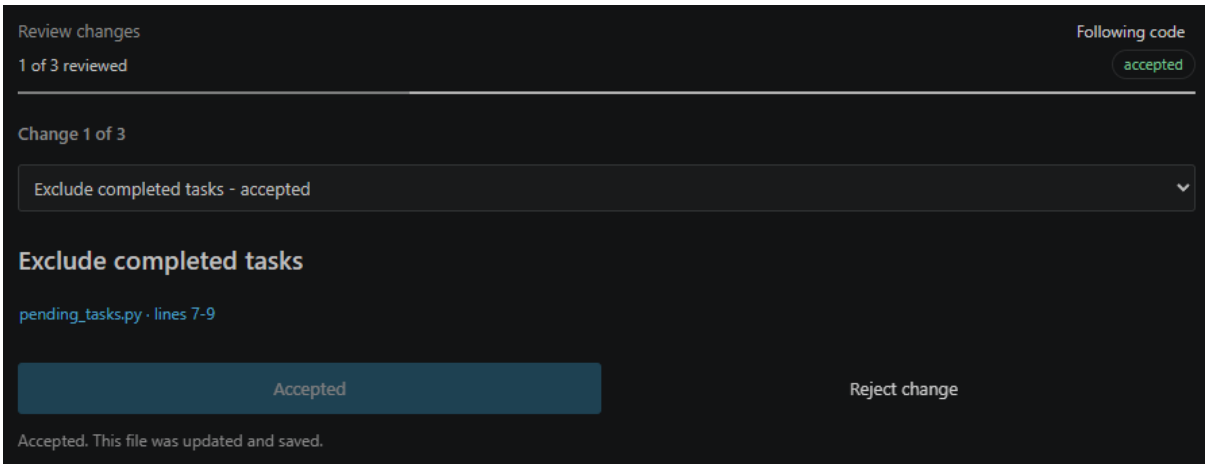
The panel links the selected change to its explanation and original/suggested code.

Decide what to keep

Accept change applies that suggestion and saves the sample file. **Reject change** keeps the original code, or restores it if you already accepted the change. Pending suggestions stay as previews until accepted.



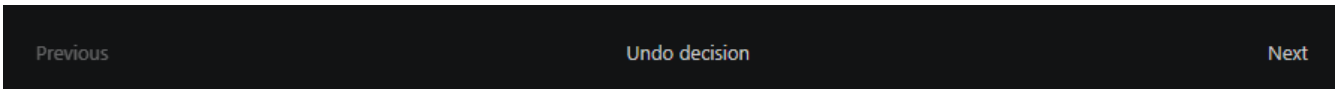
After accepting the filter, its code is saved in the sample and highlighted in green.



The selected change is marked accepted and the review count updates to 1 of 3.

Move around or undo a decision

Use **Previous**, **Next**, or the change dropdown to move between suggestions. **Undo decision** reverses the last review decision and saves the restored code.



Navigation and Undo decision are at the bottom of the panel.

Selecting affected code updates the panel. Click **Following code** to pin an explanation; click again to follow your selection. The filename/line link returns you to the matching code.

Starting over

Close the AITrace tab without deciding, then reopen it from a review entry or the editor toolbar. To reset, run **AITrace: Reset Current Case** and confirm; this clears decisions and manual edits in that sample. **Start Demo** creates a separate sample copy.

Manual edits pause review decisions. Use **Undo decision** for review actions. Start a fresh demo to keep a manually edited file. If the extension stops responding, run **Developer: Reload Window**, then start a new demo. Reloading clears the review session.